

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

ously not committing itself to backing its most lethal, most famous, most flamboyant piece of artillery in New Delhi. Indictment could mean a spell of exile—the first such scam, in 2005, had ended with the expulsion of 11 MPs. What will be the next act in this play? How will the 49-year-old politician—a mini-goddess herself by now for the faithful—prepare for this mortal combat?

That depends on how the wheels move in the larger narrative within which this one is embedded. Business czars with footprints across nations. A political empire still putting down its footprints in history. A Rottweiler named Henry. That plot's intrigue ranges over altitudes so rarefied that oxygen gets to be scarce. And, occasionally, plumbs to levels so comedic as to be worthy of a Wodehouse. The recent turn of events may have begun as the fallout of an "acrimonious cessation" of a relationship and the reignition of a long-drawn spat between Mahua and Dubey, but is in fact part of a story that goes back to 2019. On June 25 that year, near the very start of her Lok Sabha tenure, Mahua had pretty much exploded into virality with a speech against the Narendra Modi government that enumerated "the seven signs of fascism". Since then, she settled into her self-given role as the most outspoken critic of the BJP with an aplomb that seemed part of her persona—one forceful enough to itself become a factor.

People often need a face at the centre of a story—it can both help it cohere and also help distract. And faces don't come any more newsworthy than Mahua Moitra's. Suave, articulate, with a touch of hauteur, all the savvy one would expect of someone with 11 years in global investment banking, all the rhetorical flourish one would expect of an Opposition MP from Bengal. And yes, photogenic enough to be on the cover of fashion magazines—just a week before this controversy broke, it was in a powder-blue, crystal-embellished Tarun Tahiliani sari that she was going viral. Most of all, she possesses enough pluck to take on an army single-handedly. When cropped photos of her with Shashi Tharoor from her birthday were circulated around that time by right-wing handles, she shot back with the unruffled words: "Bengal's women live a life, not a lie." In short, exactly the sort of stormy petrel that threatens the patriarchal mind. And can create enough schadenfreude in many others who merely watch the hatchets and machetes in action.

That encounter with fate was soon looming like an inevitability because of how the po-